

Shark Bay

A coastline with exceptional natural features, including seagrass beds, living stromatolites, and rich animal life



Shark Bay lies 500 miles (800 km) north of Perth, on the west coast of Australia, and has a coastline that is more than 900 miles (1,500 km) long, including about 190 miles (300 km) of spectacular limestone cliffs. Another feature of Shark Bay is a dazzling white beach consisting almost entirely of the shells of one species of cockle. The bay contains one of the world's largest seagrass beds, which provides food for about

10,000 dugongs—large marine mammals related to manatees (or sea cows). In turn, these are preyed on by various species of sharks, including the great white and tiger sharks, which give the bay its name. The area is also home to more than 100 species of reptiles and amphibians, 240 species of birds, 820 species of fish, and more than 80 types of corals. But Shark Bay is probably most famous for its living stromatolites—modern equivalents of some of the earliest types of life on Earth. These are colonies of microbes that form hard domelike accretions (see panel, below).



▷ **BLUE STINGER**
A sting from this local *Mastigias* jellyfish can be painful but is not dangerous, unlike that from other smaller species called irukandji.



◁ **LAYERED LIFE**
In an area called Hamelin Pool lies the world's most abundant collection of living stromatolites. They are thought to have started growing here about 1,000 years ago.

▷ **SHORELINE SPECTRUM**
Mangrove-lined creeks, emerald waters, dunes, and mineral-stained pools come together in this aerial view of a part of the bay.

HOW STROMATOLITES GROW

The surface of a living stromatolite is covered in a mat of microbes called cyanobacteria, which in some cases develop into long, sticky filaments. These trap and bind together sediment particles into a hard layer. The stromatolite grows through the buildup of alternating layers of this hard substance and dead filaments.

